

STRATEGY BRIEFING

What 1,000 Startups Reveal About Building a Business Worth Buying

A plain-English read of a 1,000-company revenue dataset — translated into decisions for founders and investors.

PREPARED FOR: INVESTORS & FOUNDERS DATA FROZEN 30 JUL 2026

Four patterns that separate winners from everyone else



58%

of all revenue goes to just the top 20 companies. This is a winner-take-most market.



5–6×

more revenue per customer for B2B companies than consumer apps — same effort, more payoff.



2×

more reliable predictor of revenue: search rankings, compared to social media followers.



**Spikes hurt,
not help**

Buyers pay LESS for a sudden growth spike — they read it as luck, not a trend.

SO WHAT This market rewards durability and high-value customers — not hype.

THE BIG PICTURE

Most startups stay small — a small group dominates everything

1 in 5

startups ever reach meaningful revenue
(\$10,000+ per month)

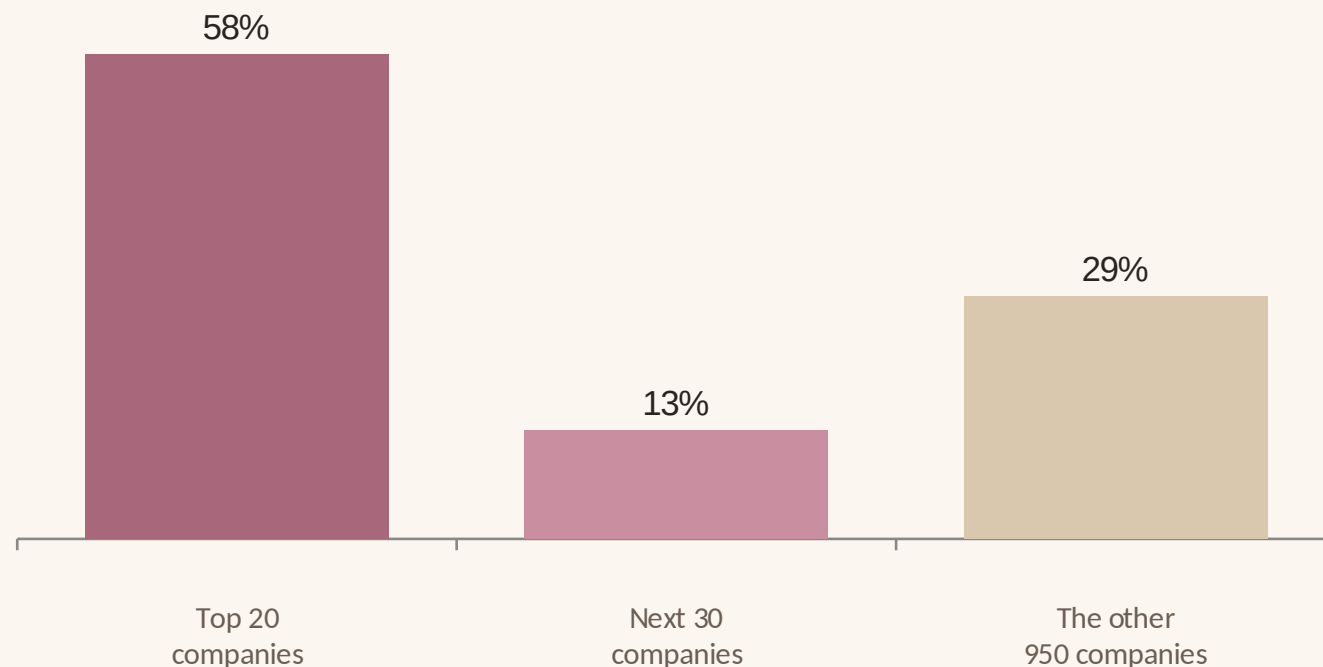
Just 16

out of 1,000 companies have crossed
\$100,000 in monthly revenue

Real example: Stan alone out-earns the bottom 700 companies combined, every month.

SO WHAT Don't benchmark against the average startup — benchmark against the top 20%. That's where the real business is.

Who Actually Earns the Revenue



Businesses pay more than consumers — every single time

MONTHLY REVENUE

B2B \$1,036

B2C \$181

5.7×

higher for B2B

REVENUE PER WEBSITE VISITOR

B2B \$0.90

B2C \$0.26

3.5×

higher for B2B

REVENUE PER PAYING CUSTOMER

B2B \$49.00

B2C \$9.34

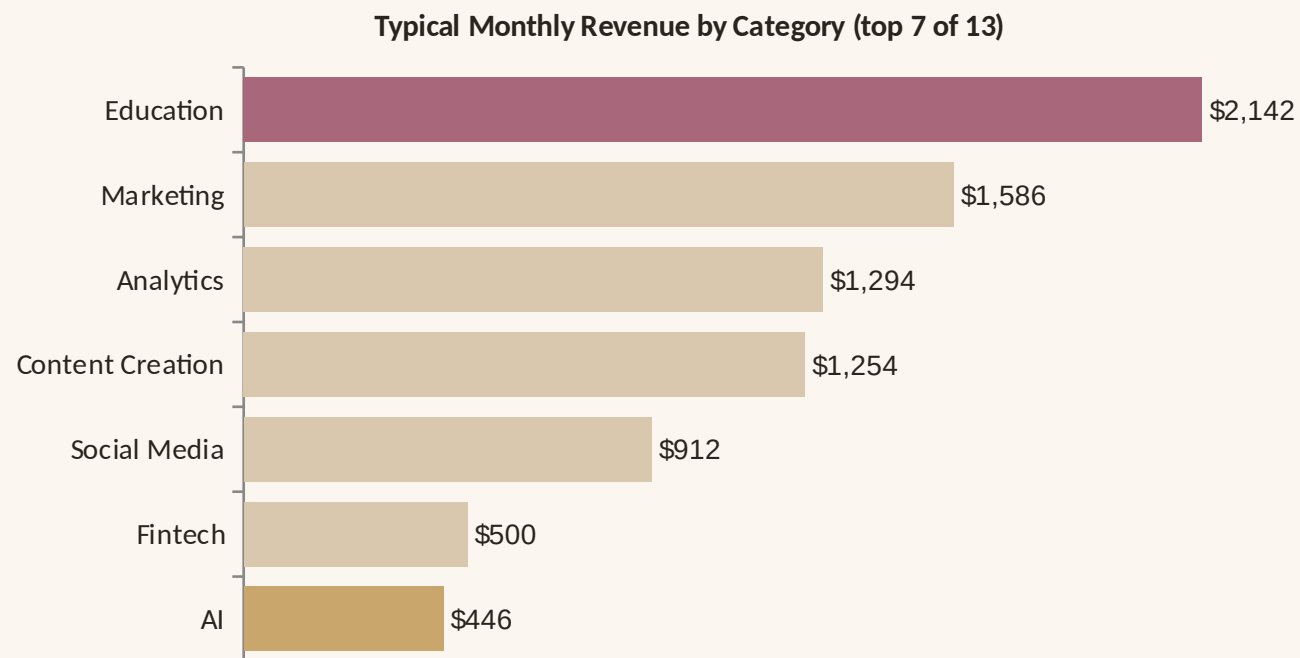
5.2×

higher for B2B

SO WHAT Same category, different buyer: Gojiberry (B2B, AI) earns \$494K/month vs. Rezi (B2C, AI) at \$260K — the buyer decides the outcome, not the label.

WHERE THE MONEY ACTUALLY IS

The best-performing category isn't AI — it's career-focused education



89%

of Education companies sell to individual consumers — yet the category still out-earns almost every B2B category.

Why: it sells career and income outcomes, like Codédex (coding, \$88K/month) — not lifestyle habits.

AI is the most popular label in the dataset — but ranks near the bottom on actual earnings per customer.

SO WHAT Winning isn't about the label you use (like “AI”) — it's about solving a problem people will pay to solve.

Top earners describe a tool. Low earners describe a feeling.



HIGH-EARNING COMPANIES SAY:

data

API

real-time

growth

ads

products

one platform

support

Concrete words that name exactly what the product does.



LOW-EARNING COMPANIES SAY:

helps you

simple

track

instantly

better

transform

habit

your way

Vague, feel-good language with no clear mechanism.

SO WHAT A strong pitch names exactly what the product does. Vague, feel-good language is a red flag for weak differentiation.

Search rankings beat social followers. It's not close.



SEARCH VS. SOCIAL

2×

more reliable at predicting revenue: a company's search engine ranking, vs. its social media following.

Real example: Stan has just 15.6K social followers and earns \$3.57M/month. TrustMRR has 23× more followers (366K) yet earns only \$22K/month.



MATURITY SHOWS IN THE DETAILS

67×

more revenue for startups on established payment platforms (like Stripe), vs. newer, emerging ones.

This is a sign of business maturity, not product quality — newer platforms just mean a younger company.

SO WHAT If you only have budget for one growth channel, pick search — not social.

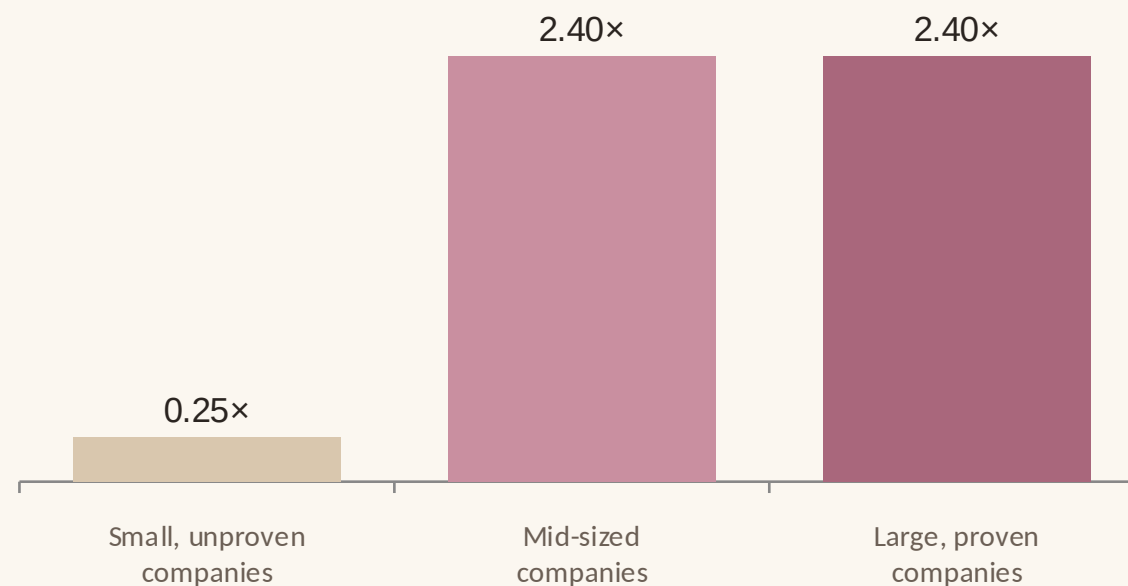
Buyers pay for proof, not for a lucky month

A growth spike actually LOWERS the price a buyer will pay.

Buyers read a sudden 30-day spike as a one-time event, not a trend — and discount their offer accordingly.

Real example: Post Bridge showed steady growth and sold for \$4.2M — 8.2× its monthly revenue. JuggleHire, with thin, unproven revenue, sold for less than 1 month's revenue (0.7×).

What Buyers Actually Pay, By Company Size



SO WHAT If you're preparing to sell: show 3+ months of steady, provable revenue — not your single best week.

Three playbooks, depending on which seat you're in



For Founders

- Sell to businesses, or sell consumers a career/income outcome — not a lifestyle habit.
- Don't lean on “AI” as your pitch — name the specific paid problem you solve instead.
- Invest in search rankings over follower growth — it converts to revenue far more reliably.



For Investors

- Discount recent growth spikes; price on months of steady, durable revenue instead.
- Expect steep discounts on small, unproven companies — the market rewards proof, not promise.
- Watch companies that sell to both businesses and consumers — early signs point to premium pricing.



For Operators

- Shift marketing spend from social growth toward search if revenue is the goal.
- If you sell to consumers, aim for career or income outcomes — not general lifestyle products.
- A newer payment platform reflects your company's age, not its ceiling — revisit in 12 months.

IN SUMMARY

The market rewards specificity, authority, and proof

- 1 Sell to businesses — or sell consumers a career or income outcome, not a lifestyle habit.
- 2 Invest in search rankings, not social followers.
- 3 Buyers pay for durability, not for a hot month.
- 4 “AI” is a crowded label; the winners sell a specific, paid workflow underneath it.